seat himself on the throne of Kabul,' he wrote in a despatch, 'and that if he did regain it, he has not the tact to discharge the duties of so difficult a situation.' Later he expanded on the same theme: 'The fitness of Shuja ul Mulk for the station of sovereign seems ever to have been doubtful,' he argued in his bestselling *Travels into Bokhara*, which collated his reports into a travel narrative.

> His manners and address are certainly highly polished; but his judgement does not rise above mediocrity. Had the case been otherwise, we should not now see him an exile from his country and his throne, without a hope of regaining them, after an absence of twenty years; and before he had attained the fiftieth year of age . . . The total overthrow of the dynasty is attributed to misplaced pride and arrogance of the last kings, who now receive no sympathy from the Afghans for their overthow. Shuja, indeed, might have regained his power, but for his rash attempts to exercise the authority of king before he was firmly fixed in it. The Afghans cannot control their feelings of jealousy towards men in power: for the last thirty years, who has died a natural death? To be happy under government they must either be ruled by a vigorous despot, or formed into many small republics.[74]

A vigorous despot was, however, exactly what Burnes had found in Kabul. Burnes had met all the Barakzai brothers on his travels, but there was no question in his mind who was the most impressive. Dost Mohammad Khan was now the sole ruler of Kabul and Ghazni, and well on his way to being acknowledged as the head of the clan despite his youth and his elder brothers' jealousy of his rise. Burnes was unequivocal in his admiration: 'The reputation of Dost Mohammad Khan is made known to a traveller long before he enters his country,' he wrote in his *Travels*,

> and no one better merits the high character which he has obtained. He is unremitting in his attention to business, and attends daily at the court house . . . This sort of decision is exceedingly popular with the people. Trade has received the greatest encouragement from him . . . and the justice of this chief affords a constant theme of praise to all classes: the peasant rejoices at the absence of tyranny; the citizen at the safety of his home; the merchant at the equity of the decisions and the protection of his property, and the soldiers at the regular manner in which their arrears are discharged. A man in power can have no higher praise. Dost Mohammad Khan has not attained his fortieth year; his mother was a Persian [Qizilbash], and he has been trained up with people of that nation, which has sharpened his understanding, and given him advantages over all his brothers. One is struck with the intelligence, knowledge and curiosity which he displays, as well as his accomplished manners and his address. He is doubtless the most powerful chief in Afghanistan, and may yet raise himself by his abilities to a much greater rank in his native country.[75]